The Voting Rights Act of 1965

U.S. Congress · signed by President Lyndon B. Johnson, August 6, 1965

Source: Voting Rights Act of 1965, Public Law 89-110

Passed weeks after the violent suppression of the Selma-to-Montgomery marches, the Voting Rights Act enforced the Fifteenth Amendment by banning literacy tests and authorizing federal oversight of voter registration in areas with a history of discrimination. Black voter registration in the South rose dramatically, making the act one of the most consequential achievements of the civil rights movement.

Connect: How did the events at Selma create the political pressure that made this law possible in 1965?

Key Passages

Purpose of the act

"An Act to enforce the fifteenth amendment to the Constitution of the United States, and for other purposes."

Section 2 — the core protection

"No voting qualification or prerequisite to voting, or standard, practice, or procedure shall be imposed or applied by any State or political subdivision to deny or abridge the right of any citizen of the United States to vote on account of race or color."

Suspending the tests

"… no citizen shall be denied the right to vote in any Federal, State, or local election because of his failure to comply with any test or device …" in the jurisdictions covered by the act.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the Voting Rights Act on American democracy.

2. Why was active federal enforcement — not simply a ban — necessary to protect voting rights in 1965?

3. How did the Voting Rights Act build on the promise of the Fifteenth Amendment (1870)?